

Ziblatt 2017 RG Notes

Ziblatt, Daniel. *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy*.
New York: Cambridge University Press, 2017.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- Question: Why did historical elites and wealthy give away so much power and security to allow for democracy, rather than entirely preventing its arising?
- Answer: “The historical stabilization of European democracies required a long-run shift, spanning the mid-1800s to the mid-1900s, in the type of political parties representing conservative social forces.... Conservatives discovered the mobilizing power of modern political parties, which allowed them to protect their own interests, in turn ironically smoothing the way for a more stable path of democratization. Political systems endured when conservatives organized their own political parties and embraced the virtues of pragmatic political action – what nineteenth-century critics decried as political wirepulling.”
- Motivating argument: well-organized and effective conservative parties (representing the interests of the elites) was the alternative to revolution, and ultimately allowed greater security for the elites even as some non-violent loss was expected. Namely, if elites successfully organized these conservative movements, then they could use democracy to their own advantage, and enjoy tempered spoils while avoiding total eradication
- Methodologically notes the importance of examining long-run trends, namely by demonstrating the ability of cross-sectionally “strong” observed democracies to be unsuccessful over the long-run. Rather, evaluating historical trends allows us to more appropriately categorize different outcomes, rather than just trying to fit pattern-seeking to immediate cases
- Another mechanism to consider – Conservative parties hindered overreach by political bodies other than the elites (sometimes the Church, but often the party or the state) and provided a mediating factor to expansion of the franchise (cooled things down, in a Huntington 1968 framework). But, when conservative parties are not equipped to do so – notably, when met with extremist or populist movements that forego these traditional

conservative political values – this balance becomes upset, and can often swing towards weak autocracy or otherwise cripple the state

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- Particular focus on the rise of the British Conservatives as the motivating success, as elites shifted to programmatic party politics
- Examines Germany as the failure case, both in Imperial and especially in Weimar Germany, where elites were excluded from electoral politics and instead had to pursue nondemocratic means of political engagement
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4 Connections

- Provides an alternative explanation to Moore 1966: it is not how coalitions of classes formed or how wealth was distributed across the economy that determined the outcome of democracy, but rather the ability of the elite to organize into a mass party. (Also a broader dispute with Moore in that the motivating actor is the elites rather than the peasants)
- Huntington & Dahl: super strong connection here, primarily regarding the ability of political institutions to appropriately facilitate inclusive political participation. Ziblatt's claim is ultimately that without well-developed Conservative parties, elites were left without democratic influence and instead turned to anti-democratic means; conversely, when elite participation in democracy could be guaranteed by means of these parties, democracy was much more likely to succeed and be sustained

5 My Critiques

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